

The Australian Government partners with state, territory and local governments, the agriculture and finance sectors, charities and other not-for-profit organisations to help farmers and rural communities get ready for drought.

We share information and seek feedback on drought-related policy and programs through online and face-to-face engagement, including the National Drought Network and the National Drought Forum.

National Drought Network

The National Drought Network (NDN) is an information sharing opportunity, hosted by the Australian, state and territory governments. It provides stakeholders with updates on drought related information on drought policy, programs and conditions.

Network meetings occur at least twice a year and can be scaled up if required. The next network meeting will be held in the second half of 2026.

The network is open to anyone who wishes to join. Content is suited to those from farming organisations, who work in or with the agricultural industry and those within farming communities – including not-for-profit organisations, charities, finance sector, unions and government sector.

If you are interested in joining, please email droughtpolicy@aff.gov.au

National Drought Network Terms of Reference – January 2026

The NDN Terms of Reference (ToR) sets out working arrangements for the network and guides how meeting and member information will be shared.

Download the Terms of Reference

If you have difficulty accessing these files, visit [web accessibility](#) for assistance.

National Drought Network meetings

The sixth National Drought Network was held on Tuesday 24 March 2026 and attended virtually by over 150 people.

The Australian Government (Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry) provided updates on:

- Current drought conditions and available support:
 - An overview of current drought conditions across Australia and the range of Australian Government drought support available. For more information, visit drought.gov.au.
 - The [Regional Investment Corporation drought hardship loan](#). For more information visit ric.gov.au.
 - Reference to current [New South Wales](#), [Victoria](#) and [South Australia](#) state-based support packages for impacted farmers and regional communities.

- An overview of current drought conditions across Australia and the range of Australian Government drought support available. For more information, visit
- [National Drought Agreement \(NDA\) annual report](#):
 - The first annual report under the [National Drought Agreement 2024-2029](#) has now been published on the NDA page on the DAFF website.
 - The purpose of the NDA annual report is to demonstrate the ongoing commitment by the NDA parties to work in partnership with each other, farming businesses and rural communities to prepare for, respond to and recover from drought. Additionally, the NDA annual report provides transparency to stakeholders.
- The first annual report under the

The network also heard presentations from:

- The Bureau of Meteorology provided an update on the current weather conditions and long-range forecast across Australia as well as the Bureau's climate and drought [communications and tools](#), including the [Relative El Niño Index](#).
- A panel session on [Future Drought Fund Regional Drought Resilience Plans](#), featuring presentations from the Future Drought Fund, Agriculture Victoria and the Queensland Department of Primary Industries, discussing regional drought resilience planning and case studies across different regions.
- A panel session on mental health and wellbeing, featuring presentations from the Australian Government, Regional Wellbeing survey and Fat Farmers discussing the latest drought related findings from the [Regional Wellbeing Survey](#) alongside the importance of community led responses to mental health and wellbeing in drought affected regions.
- The Q&A across the meeting generated discussion and shared resources including:
 - the National Centre for Farmer Health's [Support Hub](#) information and [Tackling the Tough Topics](#) guide.
 - Fat Farmers WA contingent, [Active Farmers](#).
 - Soil management programs for drought resilience such as the [Drought Resilient Soils and Landscapes grants](#).
- the National Centre for Farmer Health's

Attendees are invited to provide feedback on the network and ideas for future agenda items at any time to droughtpolicy@aff.gov.au.

The fifth National Drought Network was held on Tuesday 28 October 2025 and attended virtually by over 170 people.

The Australian Government (Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry) provided updates on:

- Regional Investment Corporation concessional loans:
 - [Announcement of additional \\$1 billion dollars for the Regional Investment Corporation](#), for concessional loans beyond 30 June 2026, helping farmers manage financial pressures during drought.

- Announcement of Government response to the [Review of the operation of the Regional Investment Corporation Act 2018](#) to be released this calendar year. The Government is currently reviewing RIC loan products to ensure they remain fit for purpose and provide meaningful support.
- Future Drought Fund (FDF) Programs:
 - [\\$27 million Scaling Success Program](#): Applications opened on 17 October and will close on 4 December 2025. This is a targeted, invitation-only grant round, available exclusively to organisations that have successfully delivered projects under eligible past FDF programs.
 - [\\$12 million Strengthening Drought Resilience on Country Program](#): Applications opened on 12 August and will close on 16 December 2025. This is a targeted grant round for First Nations-led organisations, with up to six Delivery Partners.
 - Upcoming virtual field day: Beanstalk's Drought Venture Studio, with support from the FDF, is running a [virtual field day on Thursday 20 November](#) bringing together innovators with farmers to collaborate on ideas and share information.
- The FDF Drought Resilience and Adoption Hubs Review (the Hubs):
 - Release of the [Future Drought Fund Drought Resilience Adoption and Innovation Hubs Review](#). The review, completed in March 2025, assessed performance, governance, and effectiveness, and sought community feedback to improve the program.
 - Discussion covered some of the key findings and recommendations of the report, including that the Hubs have strengthened relationships across diverse organisations to identify and deliver local priorities, but that improvements can be made.
 - [The report](#) includes 51 findings and 28 recommendations. The government will use these to inform a new competitive grant round, with an aim to open for applications by March 2026. Existing Hub arrangements will be extended for up to 12 months from July 2026 to ensure no gap in service during the transition.
- Release of the
- The 2025 National Drought Forum:
 - An [overview of 2025 National Drought Forum](#) was provided, including a summary of the key themes heard from stakeholders across the event. There was a survey run during this session that allowed participants at the NDN to provide further input and ideas via Slido.
- An
- DAFF/ABA joint communications on financial support for drought:
 - This collaboration between DAFF and the Australian Banking Association will highlight how financial institutions can assist clients affected by drought conditions and emphasise that formal drought declarations are not required to access support. Launching on National Ag Day, Friday 21 November 2025.
- Farm Household Allowance and Farm Management Deposits Information sessions. As a result of feedback heard at the National Drought Forum 2025, information sessions were provided to increase stakeholder awareness of key features, benefits and eligibility criteria for
 - [Farm Management Deposits](#) (FMDs): FMDs are a risk management tool that aims to drive increased financial resilience and self-reliance. It is a tax incentive that encourages producers to build up cash reserves in their good years. The program creates a multi-

million-dollar buffer for the agricultural industry. The FMD holdings total \$6 billion across 40,500 accounts.

- **Farm Household Allowance (FHA)**: FHA is a structural adjustment program that provides a welfare safety net to give immediate hardship relief while the recipient works towards long term financial security.

The network also heard presentations from:

- The Bureau of Meteorology provided an update on the current weather conditions and long-range forecast across Australia as well as the Bureau's climate and drought [communications and tools](#). The Bureau have launched their [new website](#) with improved navigation, better customisations such as saveable map settings, responsive design and simpler language. They will be reaching out to industry partners to offer user support. Requests can be emailed to agriculture@bom.gov.au.
- The Regional Investment Corporation (RIC) shared information on RIC loans including the announcement of \$1 billion new loan funding and hold on variable interest rates at 5.18% until 1 February 2026. The RIC also shared that they've seen an increase in applications since July 2025, particularly from Victoria and South Australia. The RIC Ready webinar will be held on Wednesday 29 October with a recording and more information on the [RIC website](#).

Attendees are invited to provide feedback on the network and future agenda items at any time. This can be done by emailing droughtpolicy@aff.gov.au.

The fourth meeting of the National Drought Network was held on Tuesday 11 February 2025, with over 120 people attending virtually.

The Australian Government (Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry) provided updates on:

- **National Drought Network Terms of Reference** - updated for 2025. This document sets out working arrangements for the network and guides how meeting and member information will be shared. The addition of the department's privacy statement provides greater transparency on what the data collected will be used for.
- **Australian Government Drought Plan 2024-2029** - released on 13 December 2024. The plan outlines the Australian Government's drought policy and programs and explains how we support farming businesses and communities to prepare for, manage through and recover from drought.
- **Future Drought Fund Investment Strategy** - released 22 January 2025. This strategy is a roadmap of how programs will be funded and delivered during the current four-year funding cycle. The strategy responds to a recommendation made by the Productivity Commission in their review of the FDF in 2023 and to stakeholder feedback requesting fewer programs, longer and more impactful programs, guided by a clear plan.
- **The Innovation Challenge Pilot** - this is a new approach to finding innovative solutions to the many challenges arising from drought and climate change. The program is currently in the design phase. As part of this, DAFF is conducting a nationwide online consultation to gather insights from experts in drought and climate policy, thought leaders, community members, researchers, farmers, innovators and First Nations People. This feedback will inform the terms of reference and grant opportunity guidelines for the Innovation Challenges grant round to be launched in

2025. Consultation closes 13 March 2025 at 5pm (AEDT) and there is a link to the Have Your Say consultation [here](#).

- **FDF Drought Resilience Commercialisation Initiative** - the Drought Venture Studio – delivered by Beanstalk Agtech – is now open for its third round of applications. Over the 2 year pilot, almost 100 innovators will have the opportunity to be part of the Drought Venture Studio and of these, 8 startups will be matched with an experienced Co-Founder for commercialisation and launch of their drought resilience product or service. Applications close on 9 March 2025 at 9pm AEDT.

The network heard presentations from:

- The Bureau of Meteorology provided updates on the current weather conditions and long-range forecast across Australia as well as the Bureau's climate and drought communications and tools. The Bureau highlighted the value of the Weekly Agriculture, Climate and Water Update. Subscribe by emailing agriculture@bom.gov.au. The Bureau re-iterated how the long-range forecast can be utilised to better understand future conditions across Australia in the coming season.
- Agriculture Victoria presented on current conditions and provided an update on [Victoria's Drought Preparedness and Response Framework](#) which was reviewed and updated in 2024. In September 2024, the Victorian Government released a \$13.5 million [drought package](#) designed to assist primary producers with decision making and on-farm infrastructure assistance.
- The Department of Primary Industries and Regions (PIRSA) presented on current conditions in South Australia and provided an update on the [drought package](#) announced in late 2024, which includes \$8.1 million in new funding on top of the existing \$9.9 million towards drought preparedness and support programs. As of 11 February 2025, the funding has been utilised for on-farm infrastructure rebates (85% allocated), SA Drought Donated Fodder Assistance Scheme (4 organisations participating), connecting communicates events grant (75% allocated) and health and wellbeing support by providing additional RFCS, Local Health Services and Family and Business (FaB) Mentors.
- The Department of Natural Resources and Environment Tasmania presented on their efforts to manage the dry conditions in 2024 including recovery activities. They provided an update on the drought assistance announced in March last year which included \$4 million in hardship grants, freight and logistics coordination and support, and biosecurity and animal welfare services.
- National Farmers' Federation (NFF) shared their role in drought policy, including high level engagement with the Prime Minister, Minister(s) and senior representatives on behalf of the industry. The NFF also provided an update on their [national drought policy](#), which aims to be a simpler document providing unified positions on key drought matters, communicate industry positions more succinctly and provide a clear policy footing.

Attendees are invited to provide feedback on the network and future agenda items at any time. This can be done by emailing droughtpolicy@aff.gov.au.

The third meeting of the National Drought Network was held on Tuesday 6 August 2024, with over 120 people attending virtually.

The Australian Government (Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry) provided updates on:

- [National Drought Agreement 2024-2029](#) – currently in effect as of 1 July 2024. This intergovernmental agreement explains how we are working together to help Australian agriculture better withstand drought.
- [National Drought Plan](#) – open for public consultation until 11 September 2024. This will provide an opportunity for stakeholders to comment on the consultation draft and inform the new Drought Plan.
- Drought conditions are being monitored across Australia – in particular Western Australia, Tasmania, Victoria and South Australia. Farmers can access support by:
 - drawing down on their Farm Management Deposit holdings,
 - accessing the Rural Financial Counselling Service for assistance,
 - seeking a concessional loan via the Regional Investment Corporation, and
 - accessing the Farm Household Allowance when individuals have taken a significant financial hit.Visit drought.gov.au for more information.
- [Future Drought Fund](#) – This year's budget committed over \$519 million over the next 8 years to the FDF for these programs as well as to enable capacity to measure and share outcomes. The performance review of the Drought Resilience Adoption and Innovation Hubs, recommended by the [Productivity Commission review](#) into the Fund, has formally commenced and is due to be completed by early 2025. New grant opportunities are opening soon and the call for applications will commence shortly. [Keep up to date on the FDF](#) by checking the department's website.
- [Review of the operation of the Regional Investment Corporation Act 2018](#) – The review report was recently published and tabled in parliament. It covered the scope of the corporations activities and appropriate governance arrangements after June 30, 2026, as well as legislation and eligibility criteria for loans, and the effectiveness of the RIC (Regional Investment Corporation).

The network heard presentations from:

- The Bureau of Meteorology, which provided updates on the current weather conditions and long-range forecast across Australia as well as the Bureau's climate and drought communications and tools. The Bureau highlighted the value of the Weekly Agriculture, Climate and Water Update. Subscribe by emailing agriculture@bom.gov.au. The Bureau re-iterated how the long-range forecast can be used to better understand future conditions across Australia in the coming season. There is also a [long-range forecast video](#) that is updated every few weeks on the Bureau's YouTube channel.
- Representatives from Foundation For Rural & Regional Renewal (FRRR) and the Australian Rural Leadership Foundation (ARLF) presented on their FDF- funded program which focuses on [helping regional communities prepare for drought](#). The initiative represents the second stage of their work towards the 'Better Prepared Communities' principle of the FDF. The program is set to run for three years (2022-2025) and is made up of 5 elements that are managed between the FRRR and the ARLF. They aim to help strengthen communities and improve drought preparation

by investing in social outcomes through leadership programs, networking, capability building, events and training.

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The second meeting of the National Drought Network was held on Tuesday 26 March 2024, with over 100 people attending virtually.

The Australian Government (Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry) provided updates on:

- The [National Drought Plan](#) – expected to be released for public consultation mid-2024. This will provide an opportunity for stakeholders to comment on the consultation draft and inform the new Drought Plan.
- The [National Drought Agreement](#) – this is currently being progressed through First Ministers for endorsement so it can come into effect mid-2024.
- The [Future Drought Fund](#) – as part of the FDF, Nuffield is offering drought resilience scholarships for the 2025 program. Applications are open until 31 May.
- The [Climate-Smart Agriculture Program](#) – two grant rounds are currently open – the Partnerships and Innovation grants, closing on 8 April and the Capacity Building grants, closing on 28 March. Information about both grant rounds is on the [Community Grants Hub](#).

The network heard presentations from:

- The Bureau of Meteorology who presented on its

[Climate Outlook](#), as well as recent media sentiment, and reflections on the Bureau's climate and drought communications. The Bureau re-iterated that the [long-range forecast](#) is the best source of information for future conditions across Australia in the coming season.

The session referenced several activities with Bureau involvement to supporting decision-making for the agriculture sector, including:

- A dedicated agriculture section who can be contacted by emailing agriculture@bom.gov.au.
- [MyClimateView](#) which is an interactive, digital platform developed in partnership with CSIRO, funded by the Department through the Future Drought Fund.
- A project targeted to informing decision-making for farmers, including a [National Training Program](#), that is now live on the Bureau's learning platform, research and products to support interpretation of the Bureau's long-range forecasts and an Agriculture Decision Support Service, that provides insights on the long-range forecast. An Agriculture Decision Support Service, that provides insights on the long-range forecast. These updates are available via [Agriculture - YouTube](#).
- A dedicated agriculture section who can be contacted by emailing
- ABARES on the Farm Performance Forecast which includes information for 2023/24 and 2024/25. Attendees can learn more by visiting the [ABARES website](#). An update was also provided

on the Drought Early Warning System, a project developed by ABARES and CSIRO. More information is available at [The Drought Early Warning System Project](#).

- The Western Australian Department of Primary Industries and Regional Development provided an update on latest weather conditions in Western Australia (WA) and discussed building biological and financial resilience farming systems. Attendees can learn more at <https://www.agric.wa.gov.au/>.
- The Future Drought Fund presented on public consultation outcomes, the Productivity Commission Inquiry and the commencement of new funding plan and Investment Strategy to be released in mid-2024. Attendees can find out more about the FDF at [Future Drought Fund](#).

Attendees are invited to provide feedback on the network and future agenda items at any time. This can be done by emailing droughtpolicy@aff.gov.au.

The inaugural meeting of the National Drought Network was held on Monday 13 November 2023, with 79 people attending the virtual meeting.

The Australian Government (Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry) said the network:

- was established to share drought related information in a timely manner from all parties to the National Drought Agreement (Australian, state and territory governments).
- complemented, rather than replaced, other engagement and consultation activities
- expected to meet every 6 months at this stage.

The network heard presentations on the:

- Australian Government decision-making framework. The framework aimed to provide a more transparent, consistent, and collaborative process for monitoring drought conditions and their impact, and to inform advice to government on drought. Attendees could learn more or contribute to the framework by emailing DAFF on droughtpolicy@aff.gov.au.
- consultation on the Future Drought Fund's funding plan. The Australian Government was [seeking feedback until 6 December 2023](#) on how funding should be spent from 2024 to 2028 under the Future Drought Fund.
- current and predicted seasonal conditions. The Bureau of Meteorology ran through its [latest climate outlook](#). It described and invited feedback on its agricultural decision support tools, including its [regular regional forecasts on YouTube](#). Attendees could learn more by emailing the Bureau on agriculture@bom.gov.au.
- New South Wales support for primary producers. NSW Department of Primary Industries provided an update on its drought assistance and support measures. These include financial support through the [Farm Innovation Fund](#) and other drought measures listed on [NSW Drought Hub](#).
- Queensland support for primary producers. QLD Department of Agriculture and Fisheries provided an update on its drought policy and programs, including the state's [Regional Drought Resilience Planning Program Network](#) and other [drought assistance measures](#). Attendees could learn more by emailing DAF QLD on drought@dfd.qld.gov.au.

The next meeting is expected to be held in the first half of 2024. Attendees were invited to provide feedback on the network and future agenda items.

National Drought Forum

The Australian Government holds the National Drought Forum every 2 years to bring together representatives from the Australian, state, territory and local governments, industry, the financial sector, First Nations communities and the not-for-profit sector. The forum provides a platform for drought policy engagement, collaboration and co-design. The topics discussed at the forum are tailored to current events, stakeholder interest and relevant policy initiatives.

2025 Forum

The 2025 National Drought Forum was held on 8–9 September in Gawler, South Australia.

This event was jointly hosted by the Department and the National Farmers Federation.

The Forum brought together stakeholders from across the drought policy space to talk about key issues, including the Future Drought Fund, at a national level.

Video transcript

Event summary

A summary of the event is now available.

[2025 National Drought Forum event summary \(PDF 196 KB\)](#) [2025 National Drought Forum event summary \(DOCX 241 KB\)](#)

If you have difficulty accessing these files, visit [web accessibility](#) for assistance.

If you have any questions about the Forum, please email droughtpolicy@aff.gov.au.

2023 Forum

The Department, in partnership with the National Farmers' Federation, last held the National Drought Forum in September 2023. At that event, over 180 representatives from government, industry, the finance and banking sector, First Nations, unions, not-for-profit and communities shared ideas and discussed the future of Australia's drought policy.

The Forum reflected on progress made in drought reform, policy and programs and discussed what further work needed to be done.

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/agriculture-land/farm-food-drought/drought/drought-policy/drought-engagement>